

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

Language Assessment Quarterly

ISSN: 1543-4303 (Print) 1543-4311 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/hlaq20

Washback Research in Language Assessment: Fundamentals and Contexts

edited by David Allen, New York and London, Routledge, 2026, 218 pp., £135.00 (hardback), ISBN: 978-1-032-75101-6

Liying Cheng & April Jiawei Zhang

To cite this article: Liying Cheng & April Jiawei Zhang (18 Oct 2026): Washback Research in Language Assessment: Fundamentals and Contexts, Language Assessment Quarterly, DOI: 10.1080/15434303.2026.2746363

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/15434303.2026.2746363

Published online: 18 Oct 2026.

Submit your article to this journal

View related articles

View Crossmark data

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=hlaq20

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

BOOK REVIEW

Washback Research in Language Assessment: Fundamentals and Contexts, edited by David Allen, New York and London, Routledge, 2026, 218 pp., £135.00 (hardback), ISBN: 978-1-032-75101-6

It has been over thirty years since Alderson and Wall (1993) famously posed their provocative question "Does washback exist?" initiating a prolific era of research studies into the consequences of language testing. The subsequent decades saw the field traverse a complex trajectory: from the initial studies to establish the existence of testing effects to a second phase dedicated to mapping the intricate, often unpredictable mediating factors that govern these effects within the black box of the classroom and society (Xie & Jia, 2025). This body of work is exemplified by seminal collections such as Cheng et al. (2004) edited book, Cheng (2005), Wall (2005) and Green (2007) in the Studies in Language Testing (SiLT) series published by Cambridge University Press. With this recent publication of *Washback Research in Language Assessment: Fundamentals and Contexts* in 2025, edited by David Allen, the field appears to have arrived at a matured yet critical juncture, termed by Watanabe in his Foreword to this volume as the third stage of the washback tradition. No longer content with merely describing the phenomenon post hoc, this collection signals a paradigm shift toward the purposeful engineering of positive consequences of assessment (testing) to support teaching and learning; specifically, a move from washback to impact by design.

Drawing upon an extensive engagement with the systemic interactions between assessment, teaching, and learning, we consider this volume a comprehensive synthesis of three decades of scholarship in washback research. It serves not only as a successor to the field's first major collection edited by Cheng et al. (2004) but as a useful guide to future work on consequential validity. The current volume is structurally bipartite, offering a rigorous theoretical grounding in Part I (Washback Fundamentals) followed by a comprehensive exploration of diverse educational settings in Part II (Washback Contexts).

RE-THEORISING THE FUNDAMENTALS

The opening Part I of the volume operates as a theoretical challenge to the passive observation of test effects. Nick Saville and Brigita Séguis (Chapter 2) initiate the volume through a problematization of the historical distinctions between washback (micro-level effects on teaching and learning) and impact (macro-level societal effects). Drawing heavily on theories of change and action from the broader social sciences, they advocate a systemic model of impact by design. This approach also connects with responsible design in applied linguistics (Weideman, 2017, 2024). Their argument is compelling: assessment providers must move beyond the role of neutral measurement specialists to become proactive agents of educational change. By building impact hypotheses into the earliest stages of test design, test developers can anticipate and potentially mitigate negative consequences before a test is operational. This chapter sets the tone for the volume, positioning that validity is incomplete without a forward-looking strategy for societal engagement.

This forward-looking stance is reinforced by Anthony Green (Chapter 3), who traces the theoretical evolution of the field. Green synthesizes early process-product models with innovation theory, culminating in an integrated model of washback. His analysis of participant perceptions, specifically the concept of overlap between test design and real-world skills,

provides a lucid explanation for why washback varies so drastically between and among contexts. Green's contribution is essential for understanding why the same test can spur innovation in one classroom while inducing rote learning in another; it is the perceived congruence between the test and the instructional mandate that drives behaviors. Even so, perceived congruence may not be the only factor governing washback variation.

Perhaps the most significant contribution to validity theory in this volume is Barry O'Sullivan's chapter on washback in test validation (Chapter 4). O'Sullivan posits that consequential validity is not merely an appendage to psychometric rigor, an add-on to be considered once reliability is established, but is central to the integrated argument for test use. Drawing on the socio-cognitive framework (O'Sullivan & Weir, 2002, 2005) and its recent iteration as the integrated arguments approach (Chalhoub-Deville & O'Sullivan, 2020), he argues that a Theory of Action must be formulated in tandem with the test's technical specifications. This requires interactive communication with stakeholders, ensuring that the test's intended consequences are understood and shared by relevant stakeholders. In our reading, O'Sullivan's stakeholder dialogue may be difficult to sustain in centralized systems where communication becomes largely unidirectional (Nguyen & Nguyen, 2025). Chapter 4 nonetheless makes a strong case that a Theory of Action must account for contexts where policy mandates override professional judgment.

Methodologically, the volume addresses the inherent challenges of conducting real-world research in ecological settings. David Allen (Chapter 5) provides a typology of research designs, challenging the traditional reliance on comparative studies. He notes that longitudinal baseline and follow-up designs, while the gold standard for evaluating reform, are often hindered by participation attrition and logistical shifts. Consequently, he advocates more flexible mixed-methods approaches capable of capturing the nuanced nature of educational change. Takanori Sato (Chapter 6) complements this by surveying data collection instruments, highlighting the underutilized method of keeping a diary as a means to capture the temporal evolution of teacher and learner perceptions, a necessary tool if we are to understand washback as a process rather than a product.

CONTEXTS, COMPLEXITY, AND CONTRADICTION

While Part I provides the architectural blueprints for positive washback, Part II applies these theories to the multifaceted washback phenomenon of global educational systems. Recent assessment scholarship has questioned the simple distinction between high- and low-stakes, a point touched on briefly in Chapter 8. This volume covers an impressive breadth of contexts, from high-stakes proficiency testing to the often-neglected sectors of aviation English and shadow education.

Johanna Motteram and David Allen (Chapter 7) examine the more established international tests of the field: International English Language Testing System (IELTS), Test of English as a Foreign Language (TOEFL), and Pearson Test of English (PTE), synthesizing decades of research into how these tests function as de-facto curricula. They highlight a critical tension: while these tests are designed to assess communicative competence, the pressure to achieve high scores often drives candidates toward test-wiseness strategies rather than genuine language acquisition. In Chapter 8, Rie Koizumi, Yusuke Kubo, Yo In'nami, and David Allen review formative and alternative assessment and show how this work overlaps with traditional washback research. In Chapter 9, Alison Bailey examines standards-based assessment for young English/multilingual learners in the United States and its washback on classroom practice. Similarly, Dina Tsagari, Karin Vogt, and Lucilla Lopriore (Chapter 10) challenge the monolingual habitus of traditional assessment. They argue that

assessing languages in isolation produces negative washback by devaluing the plurilingual repertoires of learners. This chapter is theoretically ambitious, calling for assessments that allow for translanguaging and mediation, a move that would fundamentally alter how we conceive of washback in diverse multilingual societies. This theme is echoed in the chapters on Asian education systems (Butler, Chapter 11; Xie, Chapter 12), where the cultural heritage of high-stakes examinations creates a fertile ground for intense, often negative, washback. Yuko Goto Butler's analysis of primary and secondary contexts in Asia is particularly poignant, revealing how top-down assessment reforms often fail to penetrate the classroom level due to a lack of teacher assessment literacy and resource disparities. Meanwhile, Qin Xie identifies a recurring pattern across diverse Asian higher education contexts: standardized exit tests often exert nearly identical washback effects regardless of their specific design or implementation.

A standout contribution to the volume is Yaqing Shi and Kevin Wai Ho Yung's exploration of shadow education (Chapter 13). For too long, the private tutoring industry has been treated as a peripheral variable in validity studies; here, it is rightly centered as a primary intensifier of washback effects. The authors argue that private tutoring mediates the relationship between the test and the learner, often distorting the intended construct. In East Asian contexts specifically, tutors may encourage the rote memorization of templates to beat the test, thereby stifling critical thinking and undermining the validity of the test score as a measure of language proficiency. This chapter reinforces the field's recognition that washback is often generated not in the mainstream classroom, but in the unregulated marketplace of cram schools.

We argue that the ramifications of this shadow influence extend beyond amplifying washback and reshape understandings of test validity (see our test preparation studies across contexts (Saif et al., 2019). By foregrounding shadow education, often represented by contemporary field research on test preparation (He et al., 2025; Wang & Cheng, 2025), the present volume compels a critical engagement with the existence of an unregulated parallel curriculum, a phenomenon often overlooked in test developers' validation arguments, yet one which demonstrably shapes candidates' actual learning experiences. From the dual perspectives of equity and learning, this type of research constitutes a profound dissonance, prompting a necessary re-examination of the fairness and ethical integrity of our current assessment practices. Whereas mainstream educational institutions may endeavor to enact Learning Oriented Assessment that prioritizes developmental feedback and deep conceptual understanding, the shadow education sector frequently subverts these efforts by monetizing test-wiseness and mnemonic shortcuts. Consequently, if success on high-stakes assessments becomes progressively contingent upon access to this parallel curriculum, the assessment risks functioning as an index of socioeconomic capital rather than a measure of language proficiency, thereby widening existing achievement disparities between those with the financial means to access such supplementary instruction and those without. The same equity concern may extend to technology-mediated test preparation, where access to advanced AI feedback increasingly depends on paid subscriptions and reliable digital infrastructure. Algorithmic washback may therefore reproduce the socioeconomic inequalities already visible in shadow education, an issue revisited in the discussion of technological developments below.

The volume pushes the boundaries of the field by including chapters on aviation English and multilingual assessment. Hyejeong Kim and Eric Friginal (Chapter 14) offer a sharp critique of the International Civil Aviation Organization (ICAO) testing standards. They argue that current descriptors suffer from construct under-representation by prioritizing native-like linguistic subtleties over the accommodation strategies actually required for safe radiotelephony communication. This disconnect creates negative washback, as pilots train for linguistic accuracy rather than operational communicative effectiveness.

The volume concludes its contextual survey with a forward-looking analysis of technological developments by Brigita Séguis and Tony Clark (Chapter 15). In an era where Generative AI and automated scoring are rapidly reshaping the landscape, their discussion is timely. They rightly caution that without empirical evidence to guide the integration of these technologies, we risk replacing human-mediated negative washback with algorithmically driven distortions of the construct, where automated scoring may inadvertently privilege mechanical accuracy or response length over pragmatic coherence (Xi et al., 2024). For instance, if automated scoring engines are known to privilege sentence length over argumentative coherence, washback will inevitably drive learners to produce verbose but vacuous essays.

DEFINING THE PATH FORWARD

The volume editor, David Allen, reserves his most significant theoretical intervention for the concluding chapter (Chapter 16). Revisiting the historical difficulty of identifying positive washback, a concept that has often proved elusive because it is hard to disentangle from effective teaching, Allen proposes a revised definition that resolves much of the field's ambiguity. He defines washback as: "The co-determined effect of a test and mediating stakeholder and context-related factors on teaching and learning" (Allen, 2026, p. 201).

This definition is subtle but significant. It explicitly rejects the naïve, deterministic view that a test causes effects in isolation. Instead, it frames washback as an interaction and a co-determination between the test instrument, the stakeholders, and the ecological context. Furthermore, Allen refines the definitions of directionality: positive washback is defined as reinforcement of intended educational aims, while negative washback is defined as divergence from them. This clarity allows researchers to move beyond value judgments and focus on alignment between the test, the curriculum, and the classroom reality. Operationalizing co-determination in empirical work nevertheless remains difficult.

Washback Research in Language Assessment succeeds in its ambitious goal of updating the canon. It manages to be both a retrospective on thirty years of growth and a prospective manifesto for a future where consequences are placed at the heart of test development. It is worthwhile to note that consequences of assessment have also been examined under other labels and with different focuses (Au, 2013, 2022; Dimova, 2020; Gerald, 2022). A limitation of the volume is that empirical coverage remains uneven. Despite the editor's admirable effort to include diverse contexts, the preponderance of empirical evidence remains heavily skewed toward English language assessment, particularly within the Asian educational systems. While Chapter 12 provides valuable East Asian coverage, the anthology offers limited empirical treatment of Africa and South America. This geographic focus provides deep insights into examination-oriented cultures, but it highlights a gap in our understanding of washback in African, South American, and European contexts, and in languages other than English. Future scholarship must test the impact by design models proposed here in these under-represented contexts.

Finally, in evaluating the volume's contribution, we must also consider the practical sustainability of the impact by design framework advocated therein. While theoretically robust, this model requires a considerable level of resource intensity and demands continuous stakeholder monitoring and iterative developmental cycles, which appears increasingly difficult to sustain in the current educational systems. Methodologically, our language assessment field could benefit from those developmental methods of the field of program evaluation which assesses the effectiveness and outcomes of programs, policies, and interventions. Within a contemporary testing landscape marked by rapid change, it may prove economically arduous to sustain and implement the proposed comprehensive

impact management framework. Thus, a discernible risk emerges that this framework, despite its conceptual elegance, remain an aspirational theoretical ideal rather than an operational reality within a volatile geopolitical market (Cheng, 2026). Nevertheless, by reconceptualizing consequential validity as a core requirement embedded in assessment design from the outset, Allen and other contributors of the volume have successfully placed the onus on test developers. This volume, therefore, constitutes a valuable resource for stakeholders committed to ethical stewardship, compelling the field to uphold construct validity even amidst the radical reconfigurations of assessment business models.

By demanding that we move beyond the simplistic question of whether tests influence teaching and learning, to the far more exacting challenge of how we can ethically and effectively harness that influence, this volume sets a demanding research agenda for the next decade. It challenges practitioners to move beyond a comparative view of washback and to embrace the ecological complexity of the classrooms we serve. Important questions remain about beneficence, equity, and the geographical scope of the evidence base.

REFERENCES

Alderson, J. C., & Wall, D. (1993). Does washback exist? *Applied Linguistics*, *14*(2), 115–129. https://doi.org/10.1093/applin/14.2.115

Au, W. (2013). Hiding behind high-stakes testing: Meritocracy, objectivity and inequality in US education. *International Education Journal: Comparative Perspectives*, *12*(2), 7–19.

Au, W. (2022). *Unequal by design: High-stakes testing and the standardization of inequality*. Routledge.

Chalhoub-Deville, M., & O'sullivan, B. (2020). *Validity: Theoretical development and integrated arguments*. University of Toronto Press. https://doi.org/10.3138/9781781799918

Cheng, L. (2005). *Changing language teaching through language testing: A washback study*. Cambridge University Press.

Cheng, L. (2026). Reimagining the washback ecosystem: New directions from Asia's high-stakes testing landscapes. *Language Testing in Asia*, *16*(1), Article 10. https://doi.org/10.1186/s40468-026-00424-w

Cheng, L., Watanabe, Y., & Curtis, W. A. (Eds.). (2004). *Washback in language testing: Research contexts and methods*. Routledge. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781410609731

Dimova, S. (2020). English language requirements for enrolment in EMI programs in higher education: A European case. *Journal of English for Academic Purposes*, *47*, Article 100896. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jeap.2020.100896

Gerald, J. P. B. (2022). *Antisocial language teaching*. Multilingual Matters.

Green, A. (2007). *IELTS washback in context: Preparation for academic writing in higher education* (Vol. 25). Cambridge University Press.

He, S., Sénécal, A.-M., Stansfield, L., & Suvorov, R. (2025). A scoping review of research on second language test preparation. *Language Testing*, *42*(1), 11–47. https://doi.org/10.1177/02655322241249754

Nguyen, T. L., & Nguyen, T. N. Q. (2025). Washback, washforward, and the possibility of a co-constructive harmony of test use and test development. *Language Testing in Asia*, *16*(1), Article 1. https://doi.org/10.1186/s40468-025-00406-4

O'sullivan, B., & Weir, C. J. (2002). *Research issues in speaking assessment* [Internal research report]. Cambridge ESOL.

Saif, S., Ma, J., May, L., & Cheng, L. (2019). Test preparation across three contexts: Case studies from Australia, Iran and China. *Assessment in Education*, *28*(1), 37–57. https://doi.org/10.1080/0969594X.2019.1700211

Wall, D. (2005). *The impact of high-stakes examinations on classroom teaching: A case study using insights from washback and curriculum innovation research* (Vol. 22). Cambridge University Press.

Wang, P., & Cheng, L. (2025). The impact of TOEFL iBT preparation on Chinese test-takers' perceptions of integrated speaking and writing design. *Critical Inquiry in Language Studies*, *22*(1), 64–87. https://doi.org/10.1080/15427587.2024.2448815

Weideman, A. (2017). *Responsible design in applied linguistics: Theory and practice*. Springer.

Weideman, A. (2024). *A theory of applied linguistics: Imagining and disclosing the meaning of design*. Springer.

Weir, C. J. (2005). *Language testing and validation*. Palgrave Macmillan. https://doi.org/10.1057/9780230514577

Xi, X., Mollaun, P., & Davis, L. (2024). Use of formulaic language in TOEFL iBT speaking responses: Implications for scoring. In L. Davis & J. M. Norris (Eds.), *Challenges and innovations in speaking assessment* (pp. 125–145). Routledge. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315201504-9

Xie, Q., & Jia, Q. (2025). Three decades of research on washback (1993–2023): A bibliometric study. *Language Testing in Asia*, *15*(1). https://doi.org/10.1186/s40468-025-00357-w

Zumbo, B. D. (2015,). Consequences, side effects and the ecology of testing: Keys to considering assessment 'in vivo' [Keynote address]. Annual meeting of the Association for Educational Assessment–Europe (AEA-Europe), Glasgow, Scotland https://brunozumbo.com/home/aea-europe-2015.

Liying Cheng
City University of Macau, Macao, China
http://orcid.org/0000-0002-4458-5085

April Jiawei Zhang
City University of Macau, Macao, China
aprilzhang@cityu.edu.mo http://orcid.org/0000-0003-1019-2539

© 2026 Taylor & Francis Group, LLC
https://doi.org/10.1080/15434303.2026.2746363

Check for updates